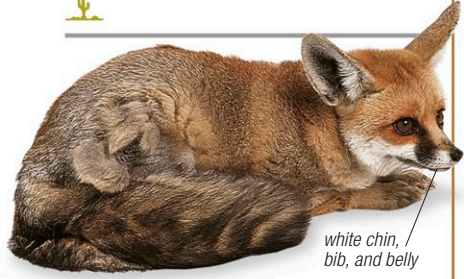


Vulpes rueppellii

Rüppell's fox



Length 16–20½ in (40–52 cm)
Tail 10–15½ in (25–39 cm)
Weight 2¼–6½ lb (1–3.5 kg)
Location N. Africa, W. Asia
Social unit Group/Pair
Status Least concern



white chin, bib, and belly

Rüppell's fox (also called the sand fox) is similar to but slighter in build than the red fox. It has soft, dense, sandy or silver-gray fur to match its arid habitat, black patches on the sides of the muzzle, and a white tail tip. In some regions this species forms monogamous pairs, but in others it gathers in groups of up to 15. It rests by day in a sheltered crevice or burrow, and changes its den every few days. Average litter size is 2–3, born in early spring. It eats a wide variety of foods, from grass to insects, reptiles, and mammals.

Alopex lagopus

Arctic fox



Length 20–30 in (50–75 cm)
Tail 10–21 in (25–53 cm)
Weight 6½–8¾ lb (3.1–4.2 kg)
Location N. Canada, Alaska, Greenland, N. Europe, N. Asia
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



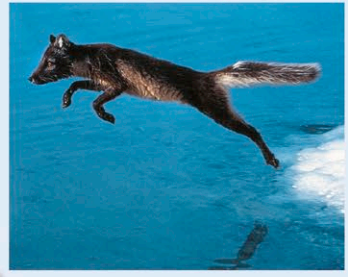
The Arctic fox has 2 color types, or “phases.” Foxes that are “white” phase are almost pure white in winter for camouflage in snow and ice. This phase is associated with the true tundra of open, treeless plains and grassy hillocks. Those of the “blue” phase are more prevalent in mixed coastal and shrubby habitats and are pale gray-brown tinged with blue in winter. The Arctic fox eats a huge variety of foods—mainly lemmings, but also birds, eggs, crabs, fish, insects, seal and

whale carcasses, fruit, seeds, and human refuse. Its social group is likewise flexible, with male–female pairs, larger groups of nonbreeders, or a breeding pair plus “helper” females. The den site is extensive, with complex burrow systems for shelter and breeding. Reproduction is closely tied to available food, with more than 15 cubs per litter when lemmings are plentiful, and 6–10 in an average year. In Russia, litter sizes of up to 19 have been recorded.

FURRED BUNDLE

The Arctic fox has small ears, a blunt muzzle, and short legs and tail, since these areas lose heat fastest. Every part of its body except its nose is thickly furred.

SUMMER COATS



The Arctic fox's summer coat is half as thick as its winter one, with less than half of the underfur. In summer, white-phase animals are gray-brown to gray above and gray below; those of the blue phase are browner and darker.

stout, rounded body under thick fur



Urocyon cinereoargenteus

Northern Gray fox



Length 21½–26 in (54–66 cm)
Tail 11–23 in (28–58 cm)
Weight 4½–12 lb (2–5.5 kg)
Location S. Canada to N. South America
Social unit Pair
Status Least concern



Also called the tree fox, this long-bodied species prefers woodland. It climbs skillfully, leaping up tree trunks and between branches with almost catlike agility. Active at night, it consumes various insects and small mammals, but may rely more on fruit and seeds in certain seasons. The Northern gray fox has a small, dark-gray neck mane and central back stripe, and a red tinge to the neck, flanks, and legs, with a buff or white chin and belly. Its den may be in an old burrow or log, but more often in a tree hole up to 30 ft (9 m) above ground, or on a building ledge or in a roof space. Most gray foxes live as breeding pairs.

VULNERABLE CUBS



The average litter size for the Northern gray fox is 4 (range 1–10). Each new-born cub is black-furred and, like most foxes at birth, helpless, with eyes closed. Its eyes open at 9–12 days and by 4 weeks it ventures from the den and begins to climb, guarded by a parent. It starts to take solid food 2 weeks later.



GRIZZLED GRAY

The speckled or grizzled coat is due to individual hairs banded in white, gray, and black.

Atelocynus microtis

Short-eared dog



Length 28–39 in (72–100 cm)
Tail 10–14 in (25–35 cm)
Weight 20–22 lb (9–10 kg)
Location N.W. South America
Social unit Individual
Status Near threatened



With its small, rounded ears, the short-eared dog resembles a raccoon dog (see p.171) but its fur is much shorter and more velvety, gray to black on the back and varying shades of gray tinged with red-brown on the underside. The black tail is more bushy and foxlike. Also known as the small-eared zorzo, this mainly nocturnal and solitary dog is a secretive, little-known inhabitant of tropical forests. It moves with catlike stealth and probably eats mainly small rodents, with some plant matter.

Pseudalopex culpaeus

Culpeo



Length 17¾–36½ in (44.5–92.5 cm)
Tail 12–19½ in (30–49 cm)
Weight 7¾–22 lb (3.4–10 kg)
Location W. South America
Social unit Pair
Status Least concern



A species of open upland and pampas grassland, this large, powerful fox is extensively hunted for its fur and to prevent predation of livestock such as lambs and poultry. Its diet also includes

rodents, rabbits, birds and their eggs, and seasonal berries and fruit. Like many foxes, it stores food during times of plenty, burying the excess or wedging it under logs and rocks, for later consumption. The culpeo's coat is grizzled gray on the back and shoulders, more tawny on the head, neck, ears, and legs, with a fluffy, black-tipped tail.

